

Assembly and Convention Emergency Preparedness Plan

South Auckland Assembly Hall

28/07/2025

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INTRODUCTION

1. An *Assembly and Convention Emergency Preparedness Plan* (CO-161) is needed for all assemblies, conventions, and other large theocratic events held at Assembly Halls and rented facilities. This plan outlines the responsibilities of the members of the Emergency Response Team (ERT). The ERT coordinates matters during an emergency. It provides initial response to help stabilize the incident scene and clearly communicates direction to all in attendance. When the facility security personnel, the police, the fire department, or other local authorities arrive, the ERT will be the point of contact for communication and will follow their direction, providing assistance as needed. For each emergency situation, there are generally three options: (1) evacuate, (2) shelter in place, or (3) a hybrid solution. This plan has been prepared taking into consideration local circumstances, such as the seating capacity of the facility, potential emergencies, evacuation routes, and so forth. However, since emergencies vary greatly and are hard to predict, the ERT should be flexible when dealing with an unexpected situation.

2. As soon as the finalized *Assembly and Convention Emergency Preparedness Plan* is received from the contract representative or Assembly Hall overseer, the assembly overseer or Convention Committee coordinator for the event should provide a copy to the ERT members and their assistants. Only these brothers should receive a copy of the emergency preparedness plan. In addition to the assigned ERT member assistants, the ERT may arrange to train other brothers to assist in caring for a response based upon the complexity and scope of the event. One to two months before the first day of the event (no less than 30

days, and no more than 60 days before), the assembly overseer or the Convention Committee coordinator should arrange a meeting with all of the members of the ERT and their assistants to review emergency plans. At assemblies, the ERT is made up of the assembly overseer, the assistant assembly overseer, and the attendant overseer. At conventions, the ERT is made up of the Convention Committee coordinator, the program overseer, the rooming overseer, and the attendant overseer. The day before the event, the ERT members and their assistants should perform a walk-through of the venue and review the evacuation and emergency procedures.

3. Although specific members of the ERT are assigned to communicate with the circuit overseer, the convention chairman, or the Public Information Department at the branch office or its spokesman, if on-site, any member of the ERT should feel free to communicate with these brothers when needed.

EMERGENCY RESPONSE TEAM ROLES

4. Assembly Overseer or Convention Committee Coordinator:

- (1) Takes the lead during emergencies. At conventions, the Convention Committee coordinator may use his assistant to help with planning and coordinating, but the assistant should not take the lead during emergencies.—See [paragraph 17](#).
- (2) Contacts or coordinates with facility security personnel, the police, the fire department, or other local authorities. Works with the attendant overseer to meet local authorities on-scene, if needed.
- (3) Coordinates training for all departments on emergency procedures.
- (4) Coordinates in advance with the accounting overseer regarding the security and handling of funds in an emergency.
- (5) At assemblies, keeps the circuit overseer informed of any confirmed emergencies.
- (6) At conventions, works with the First Aid overseer in advance to determine evacuation safe zones for those with special needs and any injuries.
- (7) At conventions, coordinates with the Public Information Department (PID) or its spokesman, if on-site, regarding any media interest in the emergency event.

5. Assistant Assembly Overseer or Program Overseer:

- (1) At assemblies, works with the First Aid overseer in advance to determine evacuation safe zones for those with special needs and any injuries.
- (2) At conventions, keeps the convention chairman informed of confirmed emergencies.

6. Rooming Overseer

- (1) He serves on the Emergency Response Team and assists where needed during an emergency.

7. Attendant Overseer:

- (1) Ensures that all attendants are familiar with emergency procedures and have received needed training.
- (2) Creates a group chat between himself, his assistant, and attendant captains in order to provide clear direction regarding evacuation needs in the event the sound system and megaphone are unavailable.

- (3) Communicates potential emergencies or security risks immediately to the assembly overseer or the Convention Committee coordinator.
- (4) During an evacuation, ensures that the facility has been properly searched and cleared, and that safe zones have needed attendants.
- (5) If needed, provides attendants for escorting media personnel and at conventions, directing them to the PID spokesman, if on-site, or to the Convention Committee coordinator.

RESPONDING TO EMERGENCIES

8. Emergency situations require quick but controlled action. If a potential emergency arises, the attendants should immediately begin investigating the matter to determine the scope of the problem. (See [paragraph 12](#).) If an emergency situation is confirmed, the assembly overseer or the Convention Committee coordinator should be notified. (At an assembly, the assembly overseer will in turn notify the circuit overseer. At conventions, the Program Overseer will notify the convention chairman.) If needed, he will initiate a call to the facility security personnel, the police, or the fire department. He will also notify the facility management or Assembly Hall oversight if needed. During an active shooter situation, anyone in attendance is authorized to call the police immediately.

9. The police may be called at **111** The fire department may be called at **111**. Other emergency numbers are:

Ambulance - 111

Poisons Centre – 0800 764 766;

Vector Electricity – 0508 832 867;

First GAS – 0800 734 567;

Auckland Council – 09 301 0101;

Non emergency Police – 105

10. At conventions, the Convention Committee Coordinator should inform the Public Information Department or its spokesman, if on-site, of emergencies that could potentially draw attention from the media. At assemblies or conventions, the Convention and Assembly Desk in the Service Department should be contacted as soon as possible.

11. Medical emergencies should be coordinated by the first aid overseer. The assembly overseer or the Convention Committee coordinator should be notified of all medical emergencies. First aid personnel should call emergency services as needed based upon the situation. Facility management may also need to be notified in the event of a serious medical emergency.

INFORMATION REQUIRED IN THE EVENT OF AN EMERGENCY

12. The following information should be provided when reporting emergencies:

- (1) Type of emergency, such as fire, accident, injury, or violent individual/active shooter.

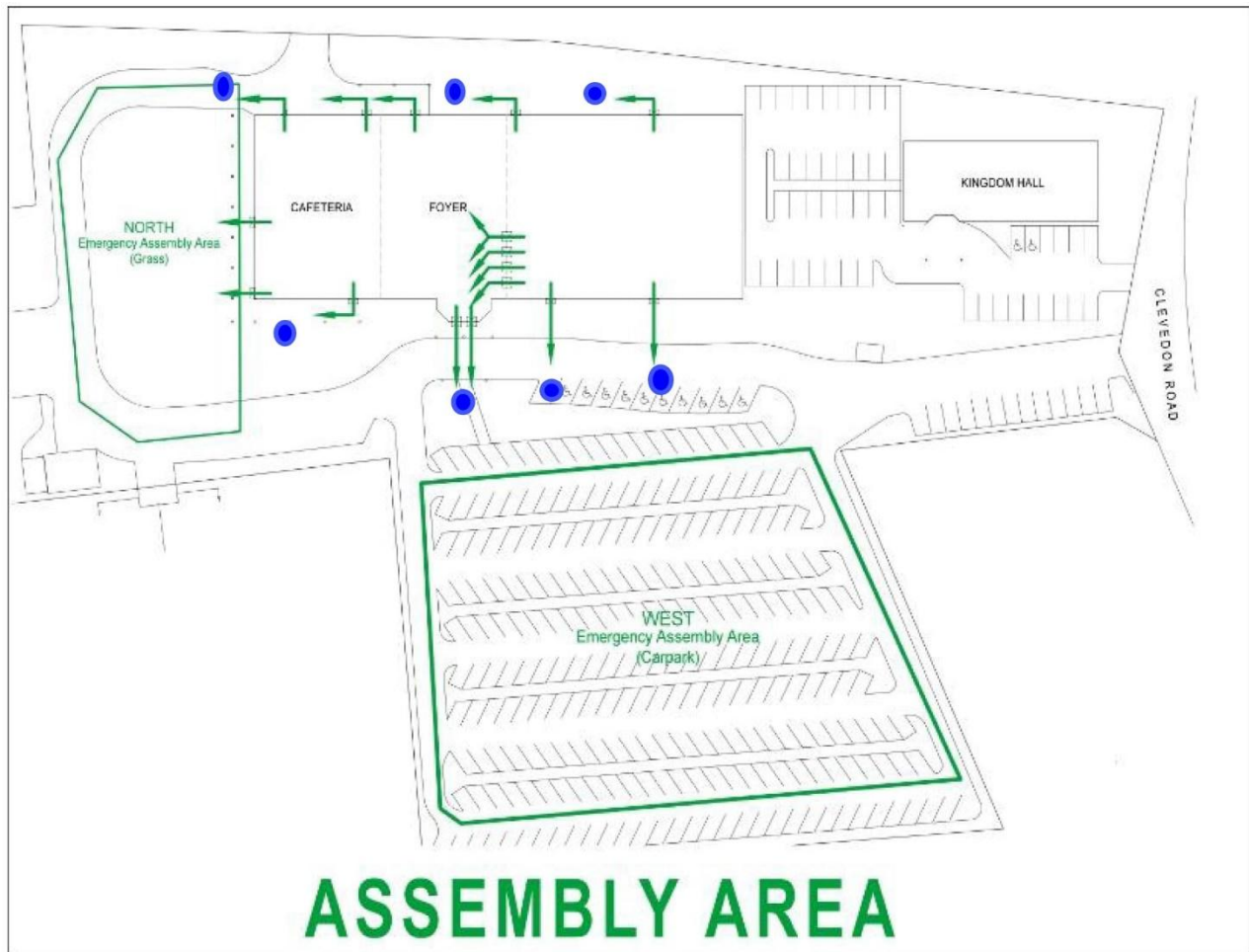
- (2) Scope of the emergency, such as the number of people involved and the size of problem.
- (3) Location of the emergency. Be as specific as possible, such as including the level or section.
- (4) Name, phone number or extension, and location of the person reporting the emergency.
- (5) Other details specific to the emergency that would be helpful to the responders.

EVACUATIONS

13. The assembly overseer or the Convention Committee coordinator will make the decision to evacuate the facility in conjunction with other agencies, such as the facility security personnel, the police, or the fire department. (At assemblies, the circuit overseer should be consulted when making this decision, if possible.) The circuit overseer or convention chairman should be quickly informed of the decision to evacuate. Often the facility management will need to approve an evacuation. Each member of the Emergency Response Team (ERT) and his assistant, the safety coordinator and his assistant(s), and the first aid overseer and his assistant should have a copy of the approved facility evacuation plan. The Convention and Assembly Desk in the Service Department should be notified as soon as possible. At a convention, the Public Information Department or its spokesman, if on-site, should also be updated. The *Risk Incident Report* (TO-5) should be completed by the Convention Committee.

14. The evacuation announcement should come from the platform or via the evacuation signal from the venue's building system. In the event the facility sound system is unavailable, the announcement should be made using a megaphone, which is located near the stage. The megaphone should be tested at the start of the event before the doors open to ensure it is operating correctly.

15. After the announcement, attendants should assist attendees to get to the assembly point(s) or away from the building if needed, in an orderly fashion. Special attention should be given to the disabled, the infirm, and the elderly. First-aid personnel should be on hand in the evacuation zones to assist any with injuries. The assembly point(s) for this venue are:



16. The assembly overseer or the Convention Committee coordinator remains the point of contact during the entire evacuation and provides direction until he is relieved of this duty by the facility security personnel or emergency services. At assemblies, the circuit overseer should be kept informed at all times.

REENTRY AFTER EVACUATION

17. Once the local authorities, the facility management, and the circuit overseer and assembly overseer (at assemblies) or the Convention Committee coordinator (at conventions) have given approval for reentry, the attendant overseer will direct the attendants at the assembly point(s) to direct attendees to re-enter the building and take their seats. The Convention and Assembly Desk in the Service Department should be informed upon reentry.

SHELTERING IN PLACE

18. Situations such as hazardous material being released into the atmosphere, severe weather, or civil unrest may make it advisable to shelter in place. Depending upon the type of incident, those in attendance may need to be moved to preselected areas within the facility,

perhaps an area with no or few windows, and take refuge. The safest place may be where the majority of the attendees are already located.

19. If the Emergency Response Team makes the decision to shelter in place, attendants will direct attendees in the main auditorium to remain in the auditorium. Any persons in the foyer and dining room should seek shelter in the auxiliary auditorium. In the event of a quickly unfolding emergency situation, all areas of the building may be used as needed.

VIOLENT INDIVIDUAL/ACTIVE SHOOTER

20. An active shooter is a person who is actively attempting to harm or take the lives of people in a confined or populated area. In most cases, they use firearms and there is no pattern or method to their actions. Such situations are unpredictable and evolve quickly. Violent situations include a wide range of scenarios such as kidnapping, physical assault, or an active shooter.

21. **“Avoid, Deny, Defend”**: Following the principles of “Avoid, Deny, Defend” can assist in quickly responding and in limiting potential injuries. These principles are as follows:

- (1) “Avoid” involves paying attention to your surroundings, having an exit plan, and quickly moving away from an attacker.
- (2) “Deny” should be used when you cannot avoid an attacker. Your goal is to deny the attacker the opportunity to do harm. This could include creating barriers to prevent or slow down a threat, turning off lights, and remaining out of sight and quiet behind blocked doors or large objects.
- (3) “Defend” should be used only when you cannot avoid an attacker or deny him the opportunity to do harm, and when you must protect yourself and others. This may involve striking out in defense.

22. **Attendant Responsibilities**: All attendants should respond quickly to help reduce the potential effects of a violent individual. The immediate deployment of law enforcement is required to stop the individual. In this situation, after saying a quick, silent prayer, attendants should do the following:

- (1) Call the police as quickly as possible. In this situation, anyone may call the police. The sooner they arrive, the less harm a violent person can do. Advise the attendant overseer or his assistant that the police have been called.
- (2) Try to prevent the individual from entering the building. This may include immediately locking and barricading both external and internal doors, even if others are still outside. Consider if there are ways to compartmentalize the building safely during an attack. This will protect the largest number of attendees. Alert others to the presence of the individual.
- (3) If the individual enters the building, make use of multiple brothers to subdue him until the police arrive.
 - If those who are being physically attacked are unable to flee, several working together can strike out defensively by using any available object. Of course, any such action would solely be to protect themselves or others from the attacker.
 - The scene and evidence should be left as is for the authorities to investigate.
 - Those serving as attendants are not permitted to carry weapons in preparation for an active shooter.

- (4) Direct attendees to an escape route away from the violence. Before using an exit, ensure that it is safe, such as by looking through wide-angle peepholes or by other means where possible. Encourage all to help others escape and to leave belongings behind. Do not move wounded individuals unless there is an imminent risk to life. Exit in the direction that police are entering or as directed by them, since this is usually the safest route.
- (5) If evacuation is not possible, encourage attendees to hide. If possible, the hiding place should be in a locked room or in some other place out of the violent individual's view. Endeavor to block the door quietly with large items. Provide protection if shots are fired.
- (6) Remain calm and instruct others to remain calm and quiet. Encourage them to silence their cell phones and other electronic devices.

23. When the Police Arrive:

- (1) Everyone, including Emergency Response Team personnel, should immediately follow the direction of the police.
- (2) Put down any items and keep your hands raised.
- (3) Avoid quick movements or pointing or screaming.
- (4) Those in oversight should be prepared to give the authorities any necessary information, such as the description and current location of the individual, the type of weapon being used, and the potential number of injuries.

24. Communication With the Branch Office:

- (1) As soon as possible, circuit overseer and the assembly overseer (at assemblies) or the Convention Committee coordinator or someone designated by him (at conventions) should contact the Convention and Assembly Desk in the Service Department.
- (2) At conventions, the Public Information Department or its spokesman, if on-site, should be updated.

BOMB THREATS

25. A bomb threat may be received through a phone call, electronic communication, from the local authorities, or other means. It may be reported by an attendee as a suspicious item. All bomb threats should be taken seriously. The assembly overseer or the Convention Committee coordinator will consult with the facility management, the local authorities, and the branch office to determine the appropriate course of action. At assemblies, the circuit overseer should be involved in this decision, when possible. In most cases, the fire alarm **should not** be activated in response to a threat. The assembly overseer or the Convention Committee coordinator may mobilize the Emergency Response Team without the use of a general alarm. If a bomb is detonated, the fire alarm likely should be used.

26. If a bomb threat is received by phone or text message, try to gain as many details as possible about the individual and the bomb. This can be helpful to authorities.

CIVIL DISTURBANCES

27. If a riot or other civil disturbance develops in the community near the event, the Emergency Response Team will ensure that the following steps are taken:

- (1) Direct attendees to avoid the area of disturbance and to avoid watching, interacting, provoking, or obstructing the people causing disturbance.

- (2) Direct attendees to stay away from glass doors or windows.
- (3) If the disturbance is inside or directly outside of the facility, the assembly overseer or the Convention Committee coordinator should call the police. Thereafter, he or someone designated by him should contact the Convention and Assembly Desk in the Service Department. At conventions, the Public Information Department or its spokesman, if on-site, should be updated.
- (4) Decide whether there is a need to evacuate and leave the area or shelter in place. The Convention and Assembly Desk should be contacted prior to making the decision to evacuate if at all possible.
- (5) Outline arrangements to assist everyone after they have evacuated. This may include communicating with the coordinators of the bodies of elders of the congregations that are attending the event so that direction can be conveyed to the congregations. Emphasize the need to remain calm and to pray for strength.

POWER OUTAGES

28. If a power outage occurs, try to determine whether it will be only a brief outage. (A large flashlight and megaphone are located near the stage.) If the outage is prolonged at an assembly, the Emergency Response Team (ERT) will make a recommendation to the circuit overseer, who will make the final decision whether or not to postpone the program until a later time. At a convention, the ERT will make the decision. In this case, please follow the general guidelines in the [“Evacuations”](#) section of this document. There is currently no provision to engage a generator on-site. It is suggested that the emergency doors in the main auditorium are opened for airflow if power is only off for a short time.

SEVERE WEATHER

29. If severe weather is expected, the Emergency Response Team will closely monitor weather conditions and decide if attendees need to move to safe locations. The following principles can be used:

- (1) Below-ground areas, such as a basement, provide the best protection from a tornado.
- (2) Keep individuals away from doors, windows, and outside walls.
- (3) Keep individuals in the center of the space, and avoid corners, because they attract debris. Select areas constructed with reinforced concrete, brick, or block, with no windows and a heavy concrete floor or roof system overhead.
- (4) Move away from areas that have flat, wide-span roofs, such as auditoriums and cafeterias.
- (5) Please see www.getready.govt.nz/en for helpful advice.
 - a. Severe Storm – Shelter in place. Tune into civil defense updates.
 - b. Earthquakes – “Drop, Cover, hold”
 - c. Volcano - Stay inside. Work with facility management to monitor ash fall on roof. Tune into civil defense updates.